
MINDFULNESS SKILLS

Introduction to Handouts and Worksheets

Mindfulness is the act of consciously focusing the mind in the present moment, without judgment and without attachment to the moment. A person who is mindful is aware in and of the present moment. Mindfulness is the opposite of being on “automatic pilot,” or being lost in habit. Mindfulness has to do with the quality of awareness that a person brings to everyday living. It’s a way of living awake, with eyes wide open. As a set of skills, mindfulness practice is the intentional process of observing, describing, and participating in reality nonjudgmentally, in the moment, and with effectiveness (i.e., using skillful means). We can contrast mindfulness with rigidly clinging to the present moment, as if we could keep a present moment from changing if we cling hard enough. When we are mindful, we are open to the fluidity of each moment as it arises and falls away.

Goals and Definitions

- **Mindfulness Handout 1: Goals of Mindfulness Practice.** The goals of practicing mindfulness skills, for most people, are to reduce suffering, increase happiness, and increase control of the mind. For some, a goal of mindfulness is to experience reality *as it is*. Mindfulness skills require practice, practice, practice.
- **Mindfulness Handout 2: Mindfulness Definitions.** This handout offers basic definitions of mindfulness, mindfulness skills, and mindfulness practice.
- **Mindfulness Worksheet 1: Pros and Cons of Practicing Mindfulness.** This worksheet is designed to help you decide whether you have anything to gain from practicing mindfulness.

Core Mindfulness Skills

The handouts and worksheets for **Core Mindfulness Skills** cover seven skills in three sets: Wise Mind; the “what” skills of observing, describing, and participating; and the “how” skills of practicing nonjudgmentally, one-mindfully, and effectively.

- **Mindfulness Worksheets 2, 2a, 2b, and 2c: Mindfulness Core Skills Practice** offer four variations for recording practice of all seven core mindfulness skills. They can be useful for recording practice after you have learned all of the core skills. **Mindfulness Worksheet 2c: Mindfulness Core Skills Calendar** offers a calendar format for recording practice of all these skills.

WISE MIND

- **Mindfulness Handout 3: Wise Mind: States of Mind.** Wise Mind is the inner wisdom that each one of us has. When we access our inner wisdom, we say we are in Wise Mind. When we enter the state of Wise Mind, we integrate opposites—including our reasonable and emotional states of mind—and we are open to experiencing reality as it is.

- You can record your practice efforts on **Mindfulness Worksheet 3: Wise Mind Practice.** (**Mindfulness Handout 3a: Ideas for Practicing Wise Mind** offers practice ideas.) Worksheet 3 asks you to rate how effective your practice was in accessing your own Wise Mind. Note that the rating is not about whether the practice calmed you or made you feel better.

MINDFULNESS “WHAT” SKILLS

- **Mindfulness Handout 4: Taking Hold of Your Mind: “What” Skills.** “What” skills are what you do when practicing mindfulness—observe, describe, or participate. Do only one of these activities at a time. To observe is to pay attention on purpose to the present moment. To describe is to put into words what you have observed. To participate is to enter into an activity fully and wholly, becoming one with whatever you are doing.

- **Mindfulness Handout 4a: Ideas for Practicing Observing, Mindfulness Handout 4b: Ideas for Practicing Describing, and Mindfulness Handout 4c: Ideas for Practicing Participating** offer ideas for how to practice each of the mindfulness “what” skills. If you are just learning these skills, your skills trainer is likely to assign a specific exercise or two after you first practice each skill in a session.

- **Mindfulness Worksheets 4, 4a, and 4b** offer three different formats for recording practice of mindfulness “what” skills. **Worksheet 4** provides space for practice of the “what” skills only twice between sessions. **Worksheet 4a** gives space for multiple practices for each “what” skill in a checklist format. **Worksheet 4b** is aimed at those who like to write describing their practice.

MINDFULNESS “HOW” SKILLS

- **Mindfulness Handout 5: Taking Hold of Your Mind: “How” Skills.** The “how” skills are how you observe, describe, or participate—nonjudgmentally, one-mindfully, and effectively. Although the “what” skills should only be done one at a time, the “how” skills can be done together.

- **Mindfulness Handout 5a: Ideas for Practicing Nonjudgmentalness, Mindfulness Handout 5b: Ideas for Practicing One-Mindfulness, and Mindfulness Handout 5c: Ideas for Practicing Effectiveness** offer ideas for how to practice each of the mindfulness “how” skills. If you are just learning these skills, your skills trainer is likely to assign a specific exercise or two after you practice each one in a session.

- **Mindfulness Worksheet 5: Mindfulness “How” Skills: Nonjudgmentalness, One-Mindfulness, Effectiveness** provides space for recording only two practices of a “how” skill for the week. **Mindfulness Worksheet 5a: Nonjudgmentalness, One-Mindfulness, Effectiveness Checklist** offers a checklist format for recording “how” skills practice, and **Mindfulness Worksheet 5b: Nonjudgmentalness, One-Mindfulness, Effectiveness Calendar** offers a calendar format for this purpose. **Mindfulness Worksheet 5c: Nonjudgmentalness Calendar** is an advanced worksheet for the single skill of nonjudgmentalness.

Other Perspectives on Mindfulness Skills

There are three sets of handouts and worksheets for **mindfulness skills** that give a different perspective on mindfulness. These are **Mindfulness Practice: A Spiritual Perspective**; **Skillful Means: Balancing Doing Mind and Being Mind**; and **Wise Mind: Walking the Middle Path**. Some DBT skills training programs may include one or more of these sets of skills.

- **Mindfulness Handout 6: Overview: Other Perspectives on Mindfulness.** This handout briefly previews the three supplementary mindfulness skills.

MINDFULNESS PRACTICE: A SPIRITUAL PERSPECTIVE

- **Mindfulness Handout 7: Goals of Mindfulness Practice: A Spiritual Perspective.** Mindfulness can be practiced for psychological reasons or spiritual reasons. A spiritual perspective on mindfulness is included for those for whom spirituality is an important part of their life. Mindfulness practice is very old, arising initially from spiritual practices across many cultures, and it has a modern-day presence in many contemplative prayer and meditation practices.

- **Mindfulness Handout 7a: Wise Mind from a Spiritual Perspective.** This handout outlines different types of spiritual practices and includes some of the many terms used to reference the transcendent. Many spiritual and religious practices share elements in common with mindfulness practices, including silence, quieting the mind, attentiveness, inwardness, and receptivity. These are characteristics of deep spiritual experiences.

- **Mindfulness Handout 8: Practicing Loving Kindness to Increase Love and Compassion.** Anger, hate, hostility, and ill will toward ourselves and toward others can be very painful. The practice of loving kindness is a form of meditation in which specific positive words and phrases are repeatedly recited, to cultivate compassion and loving feelings as an antidote to negativity. Loving kindness is an ancient spiritual meditation practice. In some ways it is similar to praying for the welfare of

ourselves and others. To record practice of loving kindness, use **Mindfulness Worksheet 6: Loving Kindness**, which provides space for describing two occasions of practicing loving kindness.

SKILLFUL MEANS: BALANCING DOING MIND AND BEING MIND

- **Mindfulness Handout 9: Skillful Means: Balancing Doing Mind and Being Mind.** “Skillful means” is a term in Zen that refers to any effective method that aids you to experience reality as it is—or, in DBT terms, to enter fully into Wise Mind. Doing mind and being mind are states of mind that, in their extreme forms, can get in the way of skillful means and of Wise Mind. Doing mind focuses on achieving goals; being mind focuses on experiencing. The polarity between them is similar to that between reasonable mind and emotion mind. In everyday life, wise living requires us to balance working to achieve goals (on the one hand), and at the very same time to let go of attachment to achieving goals (on the other hand).

- **Mindfulness Handout 9a: Ideas for Practicing Balancing Doing Mind and Being Mind.** This handout lists practice exercises. It is useful when you have already gone through mindfulness training several times.

- **Mindfulness Worksheet 7a: Mindfulness of Being and Doing Calendar, Mindfulness Worksheet 8: Mindfulness of Pleasant Events Calendar, and Mindfulness Worksheet 9: Mindfulness of Unpleasant Events Calendar** are all worksheets in calendar format that ask participants to record their mindfulness practice each day. The calendars focus on mindfulness during frazzled moments (Worksheet 7a), pleasant events (Worksheet 8), and unpleasant events (Worksheet 9).

WISE MIND: WALKING THE MIDDLE PATH

- **Mindfulness Handout 10: Walking the Middle Path: Finding the Synthesis between Opposites.** Wise Mind is the middle path between extremes. In Wise Mind, we replace “either–or” with “both–and” thinking in an effort to find a synthesis between oppositions. Ordinarily, when we are at an extreme on any continuum, we are in danger of distorting reality. This handout is useful if you have already gone through mindfulness training one or more times.

- **Mindfulness Worksheet 10: Walking the Middle Path to Wise Mind.** This worksheet lists several polarities that could be out of balance, and provides space for recording practice aimed at balancing them.

- **Mindfulness Worksheet 10a: Analyzing Yourself on the Middle Path.** Use this worksheet to think through whether you are out of balance on each of the polarities listed. “Out of balance” here means a living style that knocks you off your center, out of Wise Mind.

- **Mindfulness Worksheet 10b: Walking the Middle Path Calendar.** This worksheet offers opportunities for recording daily practice in a different format than in Worksheet 10. It can also be used in conjunction with Worksheet 10a.

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Mindfulness Handouts

Handouts for Goals and Definitions

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Goals of Mindfulness Practice

REDUCE SUFFERING AND INCREASE HAPPINESS

☐ Reduce pain, tension, and stress.

☐ Other: _____

INCREASE CONTROL OF YOUR MIND

☐ Stop letting your mind be in control of you.

☐ Other: _____

EXPERIENCE REALITY AS IT IS

☐ Live life with your eyes wide open.

☐ Experience the reality of your . . .

- connection to the universe.
- essential “goodness.”
- essential validity.

☐ Other: _____

Mindfulness Definitions

WHAT IS MINDFULNESS?

- **Intentionally living with awareness in the present moment.**
(Waking up from automatic or rote behaviors to participate and be present to our own lives.)
- **Without judging or rejecting the moment.**
(Noticing consequences, discerning helpfulness and harmfulness—but letting go of evaluating, avoiding, suppressing, or blocking the present moment.)
- **Without attachment to the moment.**
(Attending to the experience of each new moment, rather than ignoring the present by clinging to the past or grabbing for the future.)

WHAT ARE MINDFULNESS SKILLS?

- Mindfulness skills are the specific behaviors to practice that, when put together, make up mindfulness.

WHAT IS MINDFULNESS PRACTICE?

- **Mindfulness and mindfulness skills** can be practiced at any time, anywhere, while doing anything. Intentionally paying attention to the moment, without judging it or holding on to it, is all that is needed.
- **Meditation** is practicing mindfulness and mindfulness skills while sitting, standing, or lying quietly for a predetermined period of time. When meditating, we *focus* the mind (for example, we *focus* on body sensations, emotions, thoughts, or our breath), or we *open* the mind (paying attention to whatever comes into our awareness). There are many forms of meditation that differ mostly by whether we are opening the mind or focusing the mind—and, if focusing, depending on what is the focus of our attention.
- **Contemplative prayer** (such as Christian centering prayer, the rosary, Jewish Shema, Islamic Sufi practice, or Hindu raja yoga) is a spiritual mindfulness practice.
- **Mindfulness movement** also has many forms. Examples include yoga, martial arts (such as Qigong, tai chi, aikido, and karate), and spiritual dancing. Hiking, horseback riding, and walking can also be ways to practice mindfulness.

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Handouts for Core Mindfulness Skills

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Overview: Core Mindfulness Skills

WISE MIND: STATES OF MIND

“WHAT” SKILLS

(what you do when practicing mindfulness):

Observing, Describing, Participating

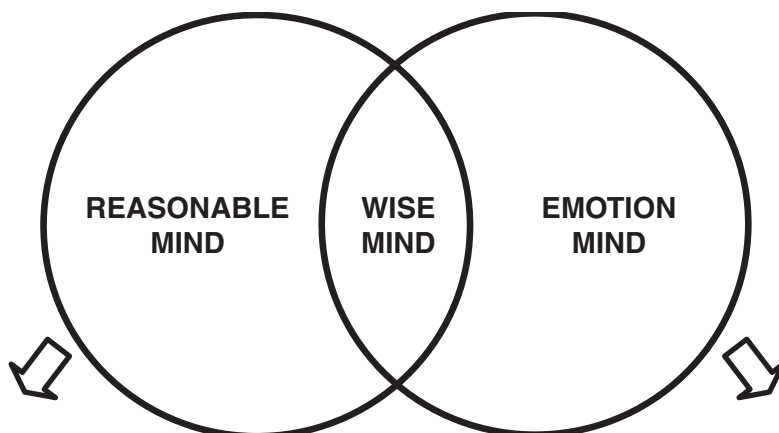
“HOW” SKILLS

(how you practice when practicing mindfulness):

Nonjudgmentally, One-Mindfully, Effectively



Wise Mind: States of Mind



Reasonable Mind Is:

Cool

Rational

Task-Focused

When in *reasonable mind*,
you are ruled by facts, reason,
logic, and pragmatics. Values
and feelings are not important.

Emotion Mind Is:

Hot

Mood-Dependent

Emotion-Focused

When in *emotion mind*,
you are ruled by your
moods, feelings, and urges
to do or say things. Facts,
reason, and logic are not
important.

Wise Mind Is:

The wisdom within
each person

Seeing the value of
both reason and
emotion

Bringing left brain and
right brain together

The middle path

Ideas for Practicing Wise Mind

The mindfulness skills often require a *lot* of practice. As with any new skill, it is important to first practice when you don't need the skill. If you practice in easier situations, the skill will become automatic, and you will have the skill when you need it. Practice with your eyes closed and with your eyes open.

1. ☐ **Stone flake on the lake.** Imagine that you are by a clear blue lake on a beautiful sunny day. Then imagine that you are a small flake of stone, flat and light. Imagine that you have been tossed out onto the lake and are now gently, slowly, floating through the calm, clear blue water to the lake's smooth, sandy bottom.
 - Notice what you see, what you feel as you float down, perhaps in slow circles, floating toward the bottom. As you reach the bottom of the lake, settle your attention there within yourself.
 - Notice the serenity of the lake; become aware of the calmness and quiet deep within.
 - As you reach the center of your self, settle your attention there.

2. ☐ **Walking down the spiral stairs.** Imagine that within you is a spiral staircase, winding down to your very center. Starting at the top walk very slowly down the staircase, going deeper and deeper within yourself.
 - Notice the sensations. Rest by sitting on a step, or turn on lights on the way down if you wish. Do not force yourself further than you want to go. Notice the quiet. As you reach the center of your self, settle your attention there—perhaps in your gut or your abdomen.

3. ☐ **Breathing “Wise” in, “Mind” out.** Breathing in, say to yourself, “Wise”; breathing out, say “Mind.”
 - Focus your entire attention on the word “wise,” then, focus it again entirely on the word “mind.”
 - Continue until you sense that you have settled into Wise Mind.

4. ☐ **Asking Wise Mind a question.** Breathing in, silently ask Wise Mind a question.
 - Breathing out, listen for the answer.
 - Listen, but do not give yourself the answer. Do not tell yourself the answer; listen for it.
 - Continue asking on each in-breath for some time. If no answer comes, try again another time.

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MINDFULNESS HANDOUT 3A (p. 2 of 2)

5. ☐ **Asking is this Wise Mind?** Breathing in, ask yourself, “Is this (action, thought, plan, etc.) Wise Mind?”
- Breathing out, listen for the answer.
 - Listen, but do not give yourself the answer. Do not tell yourself the answer; listen for it.
 - Continue asking on each in-breath for some time. If no answer comes, try again another time.
6. ☐ **Attending to your breath coming in and out, let your attention settle into your center.**
- Breathing in completely, notice and follow the sensations of your breath coming in.
 - Let your attention settle into your center, at the bottom of your breath, at your solar plexus—*or*
 - Let your attention settle in the center of your forehead, your “third eye,” at the top of your breath.
 - Keeping your attention at your center, exhale, breathing normally, maintaining attention.
 - Settle into Wise Mind.
7. ☐ **Expanding awareness.** Breathing in, focus your awareness on your center.
- Breathing out, stay aware of your center, but expand awareness to the space you are in now.
 - Continue on in the moment.
8. ☐ **Dropping into the pauses between inhaling and exhaling.**
- Breathing in, notice the pause after inhaling (top of breath).
 - Breathing out, notice the pause after exhaling (bottom of breath).
 - At each pause, let yourself “fall into” the center space within the pause.

9. ☐ **Other Wise Mind practice ideas:** _____
